



## Microwaves caused scientific panic

Scientists recently found out that unknown radio signals detected 17 years ago were from the staff microwave. Read more: <http://dgit.in/1L15znA>



# Smartwatches and beyond!

Digit had a chance to catch up with S.T. Liew, President, Smartphone and Wearable Devices Business Group, Acer Inc at the company's Global Press Conference held in New York City last month.

◀ S.T. Liew, President, Smartphone and Wearable Devices Business Group, Acer Inc.

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**Q How useful do you think smart watches are? Is it a category where the use-case is only validated once you buy the product?**

**Liew:** I feel that smart watches are used currently for a very targeted purpose. Also, smart watches come in two categories: one is the smart band and the other is smart wear like Apple and Android wear. I think that the market over the last two years has seen greater performance in the band area rather than in the wear area. There are technical as well as use reasons for this trend.

On the band area, I see continuous growth and that is because the use case for the bands is already established. People know about the experience it provides – activity tracking, calorie monitoring and so on – and hence this is sold. But, how do we grow and expand the user experience in the band area is the challenge and that is where we come in.

We are entering the market later than the FitBits and JawBones of the world and we recognize that. This is why we don't only target the user experience on those type of offering only. We have a longer view of the world. The band that we have come up with is focusing on the sports and activity area of course, but

the other thing we are focusing on is health and how to tie it all into our cloud and BYOC and IT services. From that perspective there is already a captured audience that will use the band. But on the smart wear area people still need to be convinced that it's something worth doing. Apple watch seems to be successful – at least they report it to be – but we will see.

**Q Isn't battery life a big impediment?**

**Liew:** Yes it is and that is why I have a hesitation on the wear side. On the band side this thing lasts for 5-7 days so it's okay. That's why when we define our band we are very careful about what features to include and exclude. And, also if you look at the display on our band there is no colour, it is black and white and very low light. The whole reason for this is to conserve the battery and do the key things. We carry this philosophy even with our sensors.

For example, there are two sensors we are adding to our band this year. One is a heart rate sensor where we are using optical heart rate so that it consumes very little energy because of the LED. The other one is what we call 'Galvanic Skin Detections'. The sensor itself has two gold-plated contacts touching your skin and it is very passive in current drain so

that it will maintain the battery life to what we want it to be. In heavy usage it is about four days and in normal usage it is about seven days so we feel that is more acceptable. But, to your point on the battery life on the wear side – it continues to remain a challenge, yes.

**Q Stress tracking – what does it do and what is its use case?**

**Liew:** Our wearable strategy focuses on three important pillars – fashion, life-style and health.

The stress tracking helps you manage your health. It doesn't solve you being stressful but it will help you manage your health, as it will provide you data throughout the day. For instance, the report I showed you will collect your heart rate throughout the day. It's power consumption is so low, it can actually do that. Every day it will take 150 scans of your heart rate and then take another 150 scans of your skin, perspirations and all that – that's what galvanic skin response is all about. And, through a fusion of these sensors and your activities we can tell you how stressful you are, relatively throughout the day. You can then do your review after a week to analyse what was you were doing on a particular day to be so stressful and then see how you can take corrective steps. 